"NO SOONER HAD A DUMMY, IMPELLED BY WIRES, LEAPED OUT OF BED TO TACKLE THE INTRUDER AND BEEN SHOT FOR HIS PAINS, THAN A TRAPDOOR OPENED, "MEN" EMERGED FROM BENEATH TABLES, BOTTLES AND CHAIRS CAME HURTLING DISCONCERTINGLY AT THE GUNMAN'S HEAD."

EWAN BUTLER RECALLS HIS SOE TRAINING AT THE HANDS OF E A SYKES



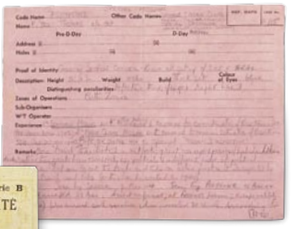
Secret air drops
The Lysander aircraft was capable of landing on very short airstrips and therefore was well suited to missions into Occupied Europe, dropping off SOE agents and supplies.

The quality of the training and equipment the agents received was mixed. For example, no one realized how quickly the Germans would track the source of shortwave radio broadcasts. Thus agents were not sufficiently warned to keep radio messages brief and avoid sending repeatedly from the same place. As a result, radio operators were often arrested almost as soon as they started their work. Agents' forged documents were generally excellent, but details, such as providing them with the right brand of cigarettes, were sometimes missed. SOE pioneered the use of plastic explosives, yet time was wasted on fanciful ideas such as stuffing explosives into the bodies of dead rats or making it resemble animal dung to be spread on roads. In general, the pressure for speedy action meant many agents went into Europe with preparation too skimpy for the demanding task that faced them.

INTO OCCUPIED EUROPE

SOE's original preferred method of inserting agents into Occupied Europe was by sea, either using fishing boats or fast motor patrol boats to land on isolated stretches of coast. The reluctance of the Royal Navy to cooperate and a battle for resources with the Secret Intelligence Service (SIS), which had the same idea, forced SOE to turn to the air. Flying by night, agents and supplies were dropped in by parachute or landed in aircraft such as the Lysander, which were capable of operating from short, rough landing grounds. An agent could typically expect to be met by a reception committee made up of members of resistance groups or fellow SOE operatives. They would arrange discreet lights to mark a landing strip or drop zone. Arrival in hostile territory and movement from the initial arrival point to safe housing were inevitably among the most dangerous phases of an agent's mission.

False identities
It was essential for all SOE agents to have impeccable documentation to support their covert lives, and thus avoid detection.



SOE FILE CARD



ORIGINAL AND UPDATED FRENCH IDENTITY CARDS



Behind enemy lines
Captain John Roper of the SOE in a wood near Savournon, shortly after parachuting into the Haute Savoie region of France.

UNDERCOVER

SOE agents were assigned a variety of roles. The most responsible were organizers, entrusted with setting up and developing resistance networks. Like radio operators and sabotage specialists, these were almost always men. Women agents were generally employed as couriers, partly because it was felt they were less likely to attract suspicion when travelling around. Living under the cover of a false identity in hostile, heavily policed territory, agents had to cope with, in Gubbins' words, "a continual anxiety all day and